



PEIRTA

Newsletter

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Prince Edward Island Retired Teachers' Association

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Fall 2026

From the President

As the leaves turn and the Island air grows crisp, I look back on a season rich with both joy and sorrow, a summer that brought our family back to the Eastern end of PEI, where we fell in love with the Island all over again.

Revisiting the East, Falling in Love Again

This summer, we returned to the Eastern part of Prince Edward Island with family in tow. There's something magical about revisiting these shores—the red soil, the rolling farmland, the quiet coves—that makes you feel as though you're coming home, even if you've been away. We spent days swimming at pristine beaches, hiking the trails at

Greenwich, sharing meals and stories with old friends, making memories with the grandchildren. It was a reminder of why so many of us chose to build our lives and careers here.

Family Milestones: New Life and New Beginnings

The season was marked by two profound family celebrations. We welcomed the birth of a grandniece, a tiny new life who has already brought so much joy to all of us. And in a moment that felt like the closing of one chapter and the beginning of another, my son proposed marriage to his partner at sunset in Brudenell. Watching the next generation find their own paths, while still rooted in the values we hold dear, has been a source of deep pride and happiness.



In Memoriam: Colleagues and Friends We've Lost

This summer also brought news of losses that have left a mark on our community. We mourn the passing of a former respected colleague at Sherwood school, Eric Kelly. We also remember Sr. Marie Burge, a champion of the Basic Income Guarantee, the founder of Cooper Institute, and tireless social advocate. And we said goodbye to Arnold Golden Smith, president and heart of the Farmers Bank of Rustico, a fervent supporter of Acadian Culture in PEI, historian, costume maker, theatre supporter. Arnold's leadership at the bank and his dedication to preserving and promoting Acadian culture—

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Adventure in the North: First Time driving an RV

Not all our travels were local this summer. For the first time, we drove an RV through the Yukon, navigating winding roads and vast, open landscapes: Mayo, Five Miles, Ethel Lake, and Tombstone Territorial Park. It was a thrilling change of pace from the Island's gentle rhythms— a reminder that even in retirement, there's always room for new adventures and unfamiliar horizons.

Visit our **new** website at
www.peirta.com

From the Editor

This is my first attempt at a newsletter using a new program because the one I have used for 18 years is no longer available. At this point it's much more work-intensive and much less user-friendly because I don't really know what I'm doing! I won't be surprised if some strange things show up in the printed copy. Bear with me, please.

On a completely different note, those of you who know me may be surprised to learn that I've become a baseball fan (well, more a Jays fan). I spent years declaring that watching baseball is like watching paint dry. (See players pose, adjust protective gear, stretch, look over

shoulder, spit, adjust gear again, remove and replace hat/helmet, spit, wait, and then--- a swing and a miss! Repeat. If anything actually happens, see it from four different angles. Then do it all over again.) I changed my attitude last year when I found myself glued to the World Series. I watched all 18 innings in one of the final games, and like all fans, was heartbroken when they lost in the final.

With my new expertise, I'm now working on making some suggestions for rule changes. For example, if a batter hits the ball half a mile into the outfield, even if it's caught, he should get a point! Points will add up to eventually equal runs. And give some credit for outs to the guy in the field who catches the ball

instead of giving all the credit to the pitcher (who obviously threw a pitch that the batter was able to hit—which he's not supposed to do!). Players have to wear a standard uniform—would some mandatory hair styling be out of order? And how about deducting points for spitting all over the dugout?

PEIRTA Executive does not necessarily agree with opinions expressed in material authored by those other than official representatives of the PEIRTA, and information about opportunities offered by others is for information only—no endorsement is implied.

Next issue February, 2027. Submit material to margstewart@pei.eastlink.ca.

If you wish to read this newsletter online instead of receiving a hard copy, send me an email and I will let you know when each issue should appear on our site and on the PEITF site.

PEIRTA Executive and Officers 2024-2026

President: Lise Morin (902-672-2896)

lise_morin@hotmail.com

Vice-President: Charlene Cain (902-786- 4483)

cainchar@hotmail.com

Past President: Phyllis Horne (902-853-2872)

Phyllishorne1@hotmail.com

Secretary: Terri Murphy MacAdam (902-940-5710)

Terrimurphymacadam@gmail.com

Treasurer: Dorothy Farish (902-432-9692)

dfarish1@eastlink.ca

Representatives by County:

Prince (English): Anne Marie Muise

ammuisse@eastlink.ca

Queens (English): Judy Hughes (902-367-7122)

jahughes.2020@gmail.com

Kings (English): Seana Evans-Renaud (902-393-6473)

saevansrenaud@gmail.com

Francophone Rep: Gilles Benoit (902-439- 6345)

gjbenoit@outlook.com

Membership Chair: Cynthia MacDonald (902-566-4680)

Cynthia.macdonald38@gmail.com

Group Insurance Trustee: Kimball Blanchard (902-892-3765)

kimballb@eastlink.ca

Pension Representative: Michel Plamondon (902-368-2224)

michelplamondon@hotmail.com

PEIRTA Webmaster: Seana Evans-Renaud (902-393-6473)

saevansrenaud@gmail.com

Newsletter Editor: Marg Stewart (902-894-8612)

margstewart@pei.eastlink.ca

President, cont'd from 1

through museums, the tourism association, and community events—made him a beloved figure across the Island.

Moving Forward with Gratitude

As we move into the quieter days of late fall, I carry with me the warmth of family, the thrill of new experiences, and the memory of those who shaped our community with their vision and generosity. Their legacy reminds us to keep building, keep advocating, and keep loving this Island we call home.

Wishing you all a peaceful and reflective autumn.

Thank You, Joyce

We were saddened to hear of the death of Joyce McCardle—PEITF president 1995-97, PEIRTA president 2016-18. Along with her many other contributions, Joyce compiled a lot of information about the history of the RTA. This history was published in segments in this newsletter, beginning in Winter 2016.

Joyce's wit was legendary—she loved to laugh and loved to make others laugh. I used to rely on her for stories for this newsletter. She always had an adventure to relate, and was frequently the butt of her own jokes. A number of these articles were published under the heading **You Didn't Ask, but...** One of them appears here in her memory.

I asked for a new dictionary for Christmas; my kids thought I was kidding so they ignored that item on my list. I just think I have everything down pat and the world changes words again. I was just getting some of the computer jargon into my head when this texting business came along. Mercy! These aren't even words—just

symbols and letters. I can understand U and R, but some of the others leave me scratching my head. In 1998, when I got a computer, I still thought PC was Progressive Conservative. And mouse? Well, my definition would be self explanatory. I have recently discovered that I am also store-name illiterate. I took a little trip to Seattle the end of November; my daughter and grand son were coming down from Edmon ton to do some Christmas shopping, so I decided to join them. What a lovely time we had together for a few days. However, I was introduced to stores I had never heard about (I lead a sheltered life). Coach was the one that snapped my wallet to attention; I had no trouble keeping my purse closed in that store. I had been looking for a small black purse; I took a quick look around the Coach store, which was absolutely crowded, by the way, and exited stage left when I saw the prices. When we got back to the hotel to compare our treasures, imagine my shock when my daughter began bragging about the deal she got on a diaper bag at Coach. Yep, a mere \$150!! This was for a co worker who asked her to look for a "bargain." I said "Lord have mercy." Those are not the exact words, but Marg wouldn't print the real ones. Oh, yes, this was a marvelous deal; the regular price would be \$300 or more. I'm still in shock. Just so you won't feel too sorry for me, I did find a little black purse at K Mart for \$9.99.

Curling, Anyone?

We are planning another Retired Teachers' Curling Bonspiel—to be held at the Cornwall Curling Club on November 6. If you are interested, circle that Friday on your calendar. There are details to be finalized, but it will be a team entry spiel (except for Cornwall curlers), with a requirement

that every team have at least two retired teachers. We will need a minimum of 12 teams and can handle a maximum of 16. Entry will be free for members of the RTA. Others will pay \$15.00. A hot lunch will be included, there will probably be a trivia contest, we will have a few prizes, and you're pretty well guaranteed to have fun! As soon as we know for sure what we're doing, and clubs are open, I will have final details posted on club bulletin boards and on the PEIRTA website. If you are not a club member, send me an email expressing your interest and I will add you to my mailing list. I will be in touch with those who have participated in the past. Entries should be sent to Marg at margstewart@pei.eastlink.ca



Address Changes



If your address changes, please notify our membership chair (contact info on p. 2) so that she can update her newsletter mailout file. If you know someone who has had an address change and/or is not receiving this newsletter or other communication from the RTA, please ask him/her to notify our membership chair. Your mailing address must include a civic address and /or PO Box number, and a correct postal code. If you would prefer to read this newsletter online, notify your newsletter editor so that you will be notified when a new issue is posted online.

Travel, Travel, Travel

You've seen me write more than once about travel insurance. Most of you know that travel insurance is important, that not all policies are the same, and that age matters. If you are working with a professional travel agent, or travelling with a reputable tour company, you will have access to good information, but if you are planning on your own, you may be more vulnerable. Target Tours, a well-established tour company operating out of Morel, PEI, recently sent out to subscribers, and posted on their Facebook page, an excellent article on this subject. With their permission, I offer you the following excerpts from their article. **Editor**



So today I want to talk about something we all don't spend enough time on: travel insurance. Not just having it, but actually understanding what you have.

Buying a policy is not the same as being protected

Most people purchase their travel insurance, tuck the documents away, and never look at them again. I get it. Nobody wants to read the fine print. But that fine print is exactly where most claims get denied.

You've probably seen the stories on the news. A Canadian traveller stuck in a hospital overseas with a bill climbing into the hundreds of thousands of dollars. A family scrambling to get someone home. A claim denied because of a clause buried in the

policy that nobody read. These aren't isolated cases. They happen more often than people realize, and they happen to good, careful people who thought they had done everything right.

The pre-existing condition trap

This is the big one. In my experience, this is where most of the heartbreak happens.

People hear "pre-existing condition" and they think it means a serious, long-standing illness. But insurers define it very specifically, and the definition can be much stricter than most people expect.

Here's what "stable" actually means in most policies: no new treatments prescribed or recommended, no change in medication, including dosage or frequency, no new or worsening symptoms, no hospitalizations, no referrals to a specialist, no tests recommended but not yet completed, and no planned or pending treatment. Every single one of those conditions has to be met. All of them.

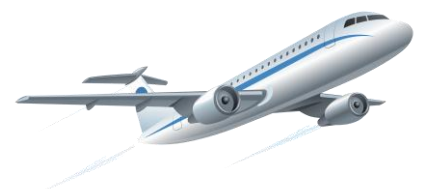
Life happens between the day you buy your insurance and the day you board that plane. A medication adjustment here, a specialist referral there, these are normal parts of life, and most people don't give them a second thought when it comes to their travel coverage. But it's worth a quick call to your insurer just to confirm you're still good to go. Five minutes on the phone could save you a lot of heartache down the road.

A quick homework assignment

Before your next trip, pull out your insurance policy, whatever you have, and ask yourself these questions:

- 1. If I had to cancel before departure because a family member, caregiver, or key employee became seriously ill or passed away, are my non-refundable trip costs covered?*
- 2. If I had to fly home mid-trip due to a family emergency, does my plan cover a one-way flight home plus a refund of my unused prepaid travel costs?*
- 3. If I'm hospitalized during my trip, does my plan cover my travel companion's out-of-pocket expenses - hotel, meals, taxis, phone?*
- 4. If I'm travelling solo and I'm hospitalized, does my plan cover airfare for someone to fly to my bedside?*
- 5. If yes to #4, how many days do I have to be hospitalized before that's covered?*
- 6. If I need a physician-recommended medical escort to fly home with me, does my plan cover that escort's airfare and expenses?*
- 7. If I lose my job due to layoff or dismissal without cause before departure, are my non-refundable trip costs covered?*
- 8. Does my plan include a cancel-for-any-reason clause?*

If you can't answer yes to all of those, or if you're not sure, you may have a gap in your coverage worth looking at before your next departure.



ACER-CART 2026 AGM

~by Lise Morin

The 2026 ACER-CART AGM took place in Vancouver and was hosted by the BCRTA at their Federation building. Lise Morin and Charlene Cain were PEIRTA's representatives. We truly appreciated the value of meeting in person, networking, discussing various provincial perspectives on issues as well as sharing provincial initiatives. Guest speakers Zena Simcoe and Chris Gallaway provided valuable information shared in the following reports.

ACER-CART will continue to raise the profile and strengthen the voice of our national association among the provincial associations and all levels of the government through ongoing advocacy, engagement, and relationship building efforts to advance our priorities. We meet on Zoom bi-monthly.

Resolutions passed by members:

1. That Acer-Cart urge both provincial and federal governments to continue to provide all benefits including OAS (Old Age Security), GIS (Guaranteed Income Supplement), CPP (Canada Pension Plan), and Seniors Drug Plan—all currently in place for Canadian Seniors.
2. That ACER-Cart develop a response directed to the federal political parties of Canada resisting Generation squeeze attempt to reduce Federal OAS benefits.

ACER-CART PRIORITIES FOR 2026-2027

1. Advocate for the protection and full implementation of the Canada Health Act, ensuring equitable access

to publicly funded health care for all Canadians.

2. Support the development and implementation of a comprehensive Aging in Place Strategy for all Canadians, enabling individuals to live safely, independently, and with dignity in their homes and communities for as long as possible.

3. Advocate for a dedicated federal and provincial Minister responsible for Seniors and Aging, ensuring focused leadership, accountability and coordination of policies affecting older adults.

ACER-CART Executive Committee 2026-2028

Lawrence Hrycan, AB, President
Sharon Penney, NL, Vice- President
Helen Sukovieff, SK, Treasurer
Bob Fitzpatrick, NB, and **Katherine SnowQC**, East co-Regional Officers
Jayesh Maniar, MB, West Regional Officer
Bill Berryman, NS, Executive Director

Award Winners

UPEI recently announced two winners of PEIRTA financial awards. The university thanked the PEIRTA for their “generous support of student success” and said “Your commitment is helping students ease financial barriers, pursue their educational goals, and build meaningful futures.” Winners are Lauren E. Folland, entering her first year of the EDPEE Primary Elementary program, and Orianna M. MacNeill, entering her first year in the EDISE Intermediate Senior program.

Excerpts from Beveley Smith's *sub-terrain: Experiences of a substitute teacher K-12*

sink the sub

My daughter was walking in the mall with me a few months ago and recognized a substitute teacher from years earlier. Her whisper to me was “There’s a lady we mentally deranged.” My daughter, apple of my eye, who was always good in school and got good marks too, admitted that when the class as a group agreed to create havoc, she sometimes went along.

One time in band class, the game with the sub apparently was for every player to change instruments for the day. The sub never realized. Interesting gambit though and when I told a grade 7 boy about it years later he said “Sounds fun.”

The problem is that kids are creative and bored. The sub is not a person but a construct, an idea, who is guaranteed to pass this way but once. It is a phenomenal opportunity to try out new antics with nearly no consequences. The teacher does not know you, can’t find you, is clueless about routines and has only limited knowledge of the consequences tomorrow of things going badly. The sub is pretty well guaranteed to need to get out of the building when the day ends and is unlikely to ever make you stay late. It’s prime territory for even nice kids to stray.

In addition, subs by repute let’s face

See *sink the sub*, 8

CLIP and SAVE!



PEITF GROUP INSURANCE

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW ABOUT THE CLAIMS PROCESSING CHANGES

We want to keep you informed about the recent change to how your Health claims are processed. These claims include, but are not limited to, vision care, physiotherapy, massage, therapy, etc. Beginning October 1, 2026, Medavie Blue Cross will take over the processing and adjudication of your claims from belairdirect.

The good news is that your coverage, eligibility and reimbursement levels will not change. This update only affects where and how your claims are submitted and processed. Below is a quick overview of what you need to know and who to contact for assistance.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is changing?

Medavie Blue Cross is now responsible for processing and adjudicating your Health claims. You should submit claims to Medavie Blue Cross through their online portal, mobile app or by mail when their provider does not offer direct billing.

Is my coverage changing?

No. Your existing benefit coverage, eligibility and reimbursement levels remain unchanged. The change relates to the processing and adjudication of claims only

Which card should I use?

You can continue to use your current Medavie Blue Cross Drug Card for all Health claims. When visiting a provider, show your Medavie Blue Cross card and advise the provider that the claims payor has transitioned to Medavie Blue Cross. Existing direct-billing arrangements should continue with minimal disruption, although providers may need to update their records.

How do I submit a claim if direct billing is not available?

You can submit your claim directly to Medavie Blue Cross in one of the following ways:

- Through the Medavie Blue Cross online member portal;
- Through the Blue Cross Mobile App, available for download beginning October 1, 2026; or
- By mail using a Medavie Blue Cross claim form.

For information on submitting claims, including access to claim forms and instructions on downloading the mobile app, visit:
<https://www.medaviebc.ca/en/members/submit-a-claim>.

Claims submitted by mail can be sent to:
Medavie Blue Cross
PO Box 220
Moncton, NB E1C 8L3

Who should I contact about a claim?

Contact Medavie Blue Cross for questions about:

- A claim that has been submitted but not reimbursed;
- How a provider can submit claims directly;

- Setting up direct deposit for claim reimbursements; and
- Plan maximums, such as the number of massage therapy claims remaining in the benefit year.

For assistance, contact

Medavie Blue Cross at:

Medavie Blue Cross

Telephone: 1-800-667-4511

Hours: 8:00 a.m. to 8:00 p.m. AST

Who should I contact about plan administration?

belairdirect remains the plan administrator for your group benefits. Contact belairdirect for changes or questions involving:

- Your address, telephone number or other contact information;
- Marital status;
- Adding or updating dependents;
- Changing a beneficiary;
- Your retirement status;
- Coverage eligibility;
- What coverage you have or are eligible to receive;
- Adding or removing coverage;
- Initiating a life insurance claim; and
- My Insurance registration, login support, site navigation or troubleshooting.

For assistance, contact belairdirect at:

belairdirect – Group Benefits Administration

Telephone: 1-800-371-9516

Email:

groupbenefitsPE@belairdirect.com

Hours: 8:30 a.m. to 4:30 p.m. AST

Please note that local belairdirect office staff will not process or reimburse Health and Dental claims. Claims-related questions should be directed to Medavie Blue Cross.

~by Nadia Roze, belairdirect



Prince Edward Island Teachers' Federation



Andy Doran

As the calendar recently turned to September, that familiar back-to-school energy and enthusiasm has reappeared. Back to school flyers and sales are everywhere and school parking lots are filling up again each morning. For decades September has meant a return to lesson planning and classroom organization, additions and deletions from classroom lists, staff meetings, and final preparations that helped ensure that the school year got off to a great start. Even in retirement your internal clock likely still ticks to the rhythm of the school bell. September has had such an important influence on your life for so long that the feeling of nostalgia when you walk into a store or see the school buses on the road at this time of year will always be a part of who you are.

The start of a new school year is a perfect time for you to redirect your lifelong passion for learning into new pursuits and challenges. Many of you will continue to stay connected to the education system through tutoring or becoming a substitute teacher. Travelling, home improvement projects, recreational activities, or grandparenting may be top of the list for some. Recently, while watching an episode of CBC Compass, representatives for the Seniors College of PEI were explaining the incredible learning opportunities that they offer. Courses in arts and literature, history,

computers, science, and so much more are offered throughout the province at a very reasonable price. Learning for enjoyment sounds like a perfect fit for many lifelong educators. One thing I know for certain is that however you choose to spend September it will be up to you.

What is PEITF up to? 2026-27 is the final year of our present contract. Pre-bargaining and bargaining will be a big focus this year.

Kristina Melane has joined the PEITF staff as a 40% employee doing member services.

Have a great fall season!



Save

Page

6.



Little Johnny: "Teacher, can I go to the bathroom?"

Teacher: "Johnny, *may* I go to the bathroom?"

Johnny: "But teacher, I asked first!"

Little Johnny's father asked for his report card. Johnny replied, "I don't have it." "Why not?" his father asked. "My friend borrowed it. He wanted to scare his parents."



Meet your new insurance sweetheart.

PEIRTA members can receive exclusive savings on home and car insurance through our official insurance partner, **belairdirect.**

belairdirect.
car and home insurance

Certain conditions, eligibility requirements, limitations and exclusions apply to all offers. Visit belairdirect.com for more details. Offers may change without notice. We offer car insurance and home insurance in Alberta, Ontario, Quebec, New Brunswick, Nova Scotia, Newfoundland and Labrador and Prince Edward Island and home insurance only in British Columbia. © 2023, Belair Insurance Company Inc. All rights reserved.

PEIRTA AGM 2026

**Red Shores,
Charlottetown**

Wednesday, November 4

Registration: 9:30 a.m.

Meeting: 10 a.m. to 2:30 p.m.

Lunch will be provided at
the Top of the Park
Restaurant

Guest speaker: Professor
Emeritus William L
Randall on “AGING AS
AN ADVENTURE”



Professor Randall is a leading
voice in the field of aging and
narrative gerontology.

Election Time!

2026 is an election year for the PEIRTA. Retired teachers are invited (indeed, strongly encouraged) to submit their names as candidates for executive positions (two year terms with the option of offering for a second term). We know now that several positions are open, including that of Queens county representative and that of Prince county representative (current reps have

served two terms). If you have any interest in serving your fellow retirees in this way, reach out to any executive member for more information, and if you decide to run for a position, submit your name to Phyllis Horne, past president and chair of the Nomination Committee.

sink the sub, cont'd from 5

it, have a bum wrap in our culture. From generations of kids who now as adults remember some less than stellar teachers, some traumatic humiliations and who never quite felt they were able to get even, the school system has a mixed reputation anyway and subs seem fair game for venting.

Maybe it's the word. Sub is linked to substandard, subversive, subliminal, and anything that substitutes seems to be less than the real thing. I'm a pinch-hitter, a stand-in, but my delusion to spur me to keep going is I am the Lone Ranger, rushing in to save the day, Superwoman in a cape, come to heroically get the kids through the lessons despite the tragic absence of their fearless leader.

But to kids I am 'just a sub.'

For the little kids now is the time to get that special privilege the teacher metes out only after careful earning and qualifying – but which the sub is clueless about. So now the kids say they can indeed use the electric pencil sharpener, they can ask for a new pencil or two even though their old one is only half used. This is when they try for the special pencil crayon kit, a new plastic pencil sharpener, anything from the big imposing 'teacher only' supply cupboard. And I have to admit that not knowing, I usually let them have the item, if it's small.

PEITF Travel Insurance

Our out-of-province travel insurance plan has a 90-day medical stability clause. This means that if you have a pre-existing medical condition, it must be considered medically stable for 90 days prior to your departure date if you are to be covered in the event of a medical emergency related to this condition while you are travelling.

A pre-existing condition is considered stable if the member, in the 90 days before the departure date, has not:

1. Been treated or evaluated for new symptoms or related conditions;
2. Had symptoms that increased in frequency or severity, or examination findings indicating the condition has worsened;
3. Been prescribed a new treatment or change in treatment for the condition.
4. Been admitted to a hospital for the condition; or
5. Been awaiting new treatments or tests regarding the medical condition (does not include routine tests).

Number 3 generally does not include reductions in medication due to improvement in a condition, or regular changes in medication as part of an established treatment plan—but each case must be reviewed individually. Call Medavie Blue Cross at 1-800-667-4511, Travel Department, for clarification if you are planning to travel outside PEI.

